Brazil

Brazil's approach to Africa's natural resources seems to be characterised by the rhetoric of indigenisation to advance its sub-imperialist interests and those of other imperialist powers. It uses its historical ties with people of African descent to sign lucrative contracts in the continent. In fact, Brazil has the largest population of black people in the world after Nigeria.

Brazil has interests in African mining. Vale, the world's second-largest mining corporation, has exploited coal in Mozambique since 2004. Other mining interests abound in Angola, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and South Africa. In infrastructure, Odebrecht, Brazil's biggest construction company, is building dams, houses and hospitals. There are also growing investments in oil, biofuel, diamonds and the supermarket sector. In energy, Petrobras, a state-controlled energy group, is acquiring further exploration rights and increasing production.

Brazil's imports from Africa are overrepresented by minerals and crude materials (which make up 80%) whereas Africa's imports from Brazil are diversified and include agricultural products (sugar, dairy, meat, cereals), vehicles and parts, nuclear reactors and machinery, ores and ash. Brazil's major trading partners in Africa consist of Nigeria (32%), Angola (16%), Algeria (12%), South Africa (10%), and Libya (7%). These countries make up 77% of Brazil's total trade with the continent.

BRICS scholar Oliver Stuenkel argues that Brazilian economic and commercial interests are becoming much more visible than before. Petronas is present in 28 countries, investing US$1.9 billion in coal, oil and natural gas in Nigeria in 2005. Eletrobras is planning the construction of a US$6 billion hydroelectric power plant in Mozambique, which will most likely be financed by BNDES, the Brazilian Development Bank, which provides more funds than the World Bank. Vale invested US$700 million in coal, oil and natural gas in Mozambique in 2007. Vale recently signed a US$1 billion deal to build a railway in Malawi to transport coal from Mozambique.

Russia

Russia's position in the race for natural resources of the African continent is ambiguous. This country takes advantages of its historical presence, relations, and involvement in anti-colonial wars and its failed attempts to create communist states in the continent to advance its economic and political interests. Some key Russian officials believe that they were left behind in the scramble for Africa's natural wealth. As then President Medvedev put it in 2009, 'Frankly, we were almost too late. We should have begun working with our African partners earlier.'